

# The Little Lantern

by JoeOkat

*A warm story about finding courage in small places.*

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Nima lived at the edge of a big, dark forest. Her grandmother lived with her, in a small house made of wood.

Grandmother was very old. Every night, she told Nima wonderful stories.

But one night, Grandmother did not feel well. Her skin was hot. Her breathing was slow and heavy. Nima was scared.

"Nima," Grandmother said, in a soft voice. "You must go to Old Tamsin. She lives across the forest. She has medicine for me."

Grandmother reached under her bed. She took out a small lantern. It was old and a little dusty.

"This lantern was mine, when I was a girl," she said. "It is small. But it is enough."

Nima held the lantern. Her hands shook a little.

"I am scared of the dark, Grandmother," she said.

"Everyone is scared, sometimes," Grandmother said gently. "Courage is not 'no fear.' Courage is walking anyway."

Nima looked at the door. The forest was black. The moon was thin and pale.

Nima lit the lantern. A small, warm light appeared.

She stepped outside. The night air was cold. The trees looked like tall, quiet giants.

She walked slowly. Her heart beat fast. But the little light moved with her, step by step.

Deep in the forest, an owl called out. "Whoo! Whoo!"

Nima jumped. She almost turned and ran home. But she looked down at her lantern. The flame was still there, small, steady, and brave.

"Just a little further," she told herself.

Then Nima saw fireflies. They danced around her like tiny stars.

Slowly, the forest did not feel so scary. It felt alive. Beautiful, even.

Nima smiled, just a little. Maybe the dark was not her enemy. Maybe it was only quiet.

At last, Nima saw a small house with a warm light in the window. It was Old Tamsin's home.

Old Tamsin opened the door. "A traveler, so late?" she said kindly.

"My grandmother is sick," Nima said. "I need medicine, please."

Old Tamsin nodded and gave her a small bottle. "Walk safe, little one. Your light will guide you."

The walk home felt shorter. Nima was still a little afraid, but now she knew something new: fear and courage can walk together.

Grandmother drank the medicine slowly. Color came back to her cheeks.

"You did it," Grandmother whispered, smiling. "You found your courage."

"No," Nima said. "I just followed the light."

Grandmother laughed softly. "The light was never the point, dear. It was always you."

After that night, Nima was still scared of the dark, sometimes. But she was not afraid of *being* scared anymore.

Every evening, she put the little lantern in the window. Its warm light welcomed neighbors, friends, and travelers walking home.

A small light, in a small place. But enough. Always enough.

### **New words**

**lantern:** a small light that people can carry

**courage:** being brave, even when you feel afraid

**forest:** a large area of trees, like a big wood

**medicine:** something you take to feel better when you are sick

**firefly:** a small insect that makes light at night

**whisper:** to say something very quietly

Thank you for reading.